

D649

Crisis Communication

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer _____	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
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Items

1.

A snack-food manufacturer that sponsors a youth baseball league notices rising social media posts about stomach illness tied to one product batch, but there are no official health reports yet. Which stage is this, and what should the company do?

- A. Promote the baseball sponsorship to shift attention.
- B. Post-crisis: write a lessons-learned report.
- C. Ignore it until officials confirm a problem.
- D. Pre-crisis: investigate the signal and activate the crisis team to prepare.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

An organization reviews how it handled a crisis, updates its plan, and follows up with affected stakeholders. Which stage is this?

- A. Post-crisis
- B. Pre-crisis
- C. Crisis response
- D. No stage; a crisis ends when the news stops covering it.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3.

A chemical plant that recently repaved its parking lot had a toxic leak because managers knowingly skipped required safety inspections to save money. Under SCCT, what is the crisis type and best strategy?

- A. Attack those who report the leak.
- B. Preventable; rebuild with a full apology and corrective action.
- C. Accidental; offer an excuse.
- D. Victim; deny responsibility.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A company's warehouse is destroyed by a tornado. Under SCCT, what is the cluster and fitting approach?

- A.** Victim cluster; give instructing and adjusting information and show care.
- B.** No communication needed because it wasn't their fault.
- C.** Preventable; issue a full apology accepting blame.
- D.** Accidental; justify the damage.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5.

A gas leak is reported at an apartment complex run by a property firm that recently won a customer-service award. What should the first public message include?

- A.** Who should leave, where to go, what to avoid, and where to get updates.
- B.** The firm's award and service record.
- C.** The results of the investigation into the cause.
- D.** Compensation details for residents.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A company's first statement during an active chemical spill opens with the CEO's regret and company values and ends with evacuation instructions. What is wrong?

- A.** Nothing; values first builds trust.
- B.** It should wait until the cause is known.
- C.** The order is reversed; evacuation instructions must come first.
- D.** It should leave out regret entirely.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7.

A software company with a new office in Austin discovers a data breach affecting 50,000 customers. No reporter knows yet. What is the best action?

- A.** Wait until the investigation is 100% complete.
- B.** Wait until a reporter calls.
- C.** Disclose quickly on its own, with what is known and what customers should do.
- D.** Announce the Austin office to change the subject.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8.

During a hospital power outage, reporters ask a trained spokesperson with 20 years of experience whether a patient's death was caused by the outage. The cause is not yet known. The hospital cafeteria stayed open. What is the best response?

- A. Note that the cafeteria stayed open.
- B. Say what is known, that the cause is under review, and when the next update will come.
- C. "No comment."
- D. Say the death was unrelated to the outage.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which spokesperson behavior damages credibility most during a crisis?

- A. Expressing concern for those affected.
- B. Guessing at the cause to fill airtime.
- C. Repeating the same key message.
- D. Saying "We don't know yet; we'll update at 3 p.m."

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10.

A reporter asks the spokesperson for a bus company with a new electric fleet, "Isn't it true your drivers are overworked?" Drivers' hours are within legal limits, and the spokesperson wants to address safety. What is the best technique?

- A. Say, "Our drivers are not overworked."
- B. Tell the reporter the question is unfair.
- C. Briefly state that drivers' hours are within legal limits, then bridge to the company's safety practices.
- D. Ignore the question and talk about the electric fleet.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11.

During a product recall at an appliance maker with 2,000 employees, customer-service reps learn about the recall from the news as customers start calling. Headquarters recently opened a new gym. What was missed?

- A.** An announcement about the new gym.
- B.** Nothing; employees don't need to know.
- C.** Only executives needed a briefing.
- D.** Briefing employees, especially frontline staff, with talking points before or with the public announcement.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12.

A university with 30,000 students is building a crisis plan. The campus is known for its clock tower. Which element enables the fastest coordinated response?

- A.** A single printed copy kept in the president's office.
- B.** Writing all messages after a crisis starts.
- C.** A plan to ring the clock tower bell.
- D.** A crisis team with defined roles, pre-approved holding statements, current contact lists, and regular drills.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer D Concept 1

A snack-food manufacturer ~~that sponsors a youth baseball league~~ notices rising social media posts about stomach illness tied to one product batch, but there are no official health reports yet. Which stage is this, and what should the company do?

Target word: stage and action **Decides:** Early warning signs before a confirmed crisis.

A	Camouflage	Distraction doesn't address the signal.
B	Inverted operation	The crisis hasn't even begun.
C	Dropped element	Skips the chance to prevent or prepare.
D	Correct	Signal detection belongs to pre-crisis; act before it grows.

2. Answer A Concept 1 • transfer

An organization reviews how it handled a crisis, updates its plan, and follows up with affected stakeholders. Which stage is this?

Target word: name the stage **Decides:** Evaluation and follow-up after the event.

A	Correct	Learning and follow-up happen after the event.
B	Inverted operation	Pre-crisis is detection and preparation before an event.
C	Confusion set	Response is the acute action phase.
D	Absolute language	Post-crisis work continues after coverage fades.

3. Answer B Concept 2

A chemical plant ~~that recently repaved its parking lot~~ had a toxic leak because managers knowingly skipped required safety inspections to save money. Under SCCT, what is the crisis type and best strategy?

Target word: SCCT cluster and strategy **Decides:** Managers knowingly broke rules: high responsibility.

A	Inverted operation	The most defensive move in the highest-responsibility case.
B	Correct	High responsibility calls for accommodative strategies.
C	Adjacent category	Knowingly skipping inspections isn't an accident.
D	Confusion set	The company caused it.

4. Answer A Concept 2 • transfer

A company's warehouse is destroyed by a tornado. Under SCCT, what is the cluster and fitting approach?

Target word: SCCT for low responsibility **Decides:** Natural disaster: organization is a victim.

A	Correct	Low responsibility; focus on safety and support.
B	Dropped element	Stakeholders still need information.
C	Inverted operation	Accepting blame for a tornado misreads responsibility.
D	Adjacent category	Not an accident the company caused.

5. Answer A Concept 3

A gas leak is reported at an apartment complex run by a property firm ~~that recently won a customer service award~~. What should the first public message include?

Target word: first message content **Decides:** An active physical threat.

A	Correct	Instructing information for physical safety comes first.
B	Camouflage	Reputation, not safety.
C	Inverted operation	Cause comes later; safety first.
D	Dropped element	Adjusting information comes after safety instructions.

6. Answer C Concept 3 • transfer

A company's first statement during an active chemical spill opens with the CEO's regret and company values and ends with evacuation instructions. What is wrong?

Target word: diagnose order **Decides:** Safety is buried.

A	Inverted operation	Values before safety puts people at risk.
B	Dropped element	Safety instructions can't wait.
C	Correct	Instructing information leads.
D	Absolute language	Concern is fine after safety.

7. Answer C Concept 4

A software company ~~with a new office in Austin~~ discovers a data breach affecting 50,000 customers. No reporter knows yet. What is the best action?

Target word: timing **Decides:** The company knows first.

A	Absolute language	Customers need to protect themselves now.
B	Inverted operation	Lets others frame the story.
C	Correct	Stealing thunder builds credibility and limits damage.
D	Camouflage	Distraction damages trust.

8. Answer B Concept 5

During a hospital power outage, reporters ask a trained spokesperson ~~with 20 years of experience~~ whether a patient's death was caused by the outage. The cause is not yet known. ~~The hospital cafeteria stayed open.~~ What is the best response?

Target word: spokesperson answer **Decides:** Cause unknown.

A	Camouflage	Irrelevant and dismissive.
B	Correct	Honest, no speculation, sets expectations.
C	Dropped element	Sounds like hiding something.
D	Inverted operation	Speculation that may prove false.

9. Answer B Concept 5 • transfer

Which spokesperson behavior damages credibility most during a crisis?

Target word: find the harmful behavior **Decides:** Speculation.

A	Confusion set	Compassion helps credibility.
B	Correct	Wrong guesses destroy trust.
C	Adjacent category	Consistency helps.
D	Inverted operation	That builds credibility.

10. Answer C Concept 6

A reporter asks the spokesperson for a bus company ~~with a new electric fleet~~, “Isn’t it true your drivers are overworked?” Drivers’ hours are within legal limits, and the spokesperson wants to address safety. What is the best technique?

Target word: interview technique **Decides:** Loaded question; key message is safety.

A	Confusion set	Repeats the negative frame.
B	Inverted operation	Arguing shifts the story to the conflict.
C	Correct	Answer, then bridge to the key message.
D	Camouflage	Dodging looks evasive.

11. Answer D Concept 7

During a product recall at an appliance maker ~~with 2,000 employees~~, customer-service reps learn about the recall from the news as customers start calling. ~~Headquarters recently opened a new gym~~. What was missed?

Target word: missed step **Decides:** Frontline staff weren’t briefed.

A	Camouflage	Irrelevant.
B	Dropped element	Staff are stakeholders and messengers.
C	Absolute language	Frontline reps take the calls.
D	Correct	Frontline staff must be ready to speak for the company.

12. Answer D Concept 8

A university ~~with 30,000 students~~ is building a crisis plan. ~~The campus is known for its clock tower~~. Which element enables the fastest coordinated response?

Target word: key plan element **Decides:** Preparation before the crisis.

A	Dropped element	Not accessible or practiced.
B	Inverted operation	Too slow.
C	Camouflage	Not a coordinated communication plan.
D	Correct	Preparation speeds a coordinated response.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owned.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	7	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	0	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	3	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	11	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	4	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	4	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	7	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	Crisis stages	Pre-crisis = detect signals, prevent, prepare; crisis response = act and communicate; post-crisis = evaluate, follow up, and update the plan.	Waiting for confirmation before doing anything with early warning signs.	Early signals vs. aftermath activities.
2	Situational crisis communication theory (SCCT)	Match the response to attributed responsibility: victim cluster (low) → instruct and adjust; accidental → excuse/justify with care; preventable (high) → rebuild with apology and corrective action.	Denying or excusing a preventable crisis, or over-apologizing for a natural disaster.	How much the organization caused the crisis.
3	Instructing information first	The first message tells people how to protect themselves physically; adjusting information and reputation come after.	Leading with regret, values, or company background.	An ongoing physical threat.
4	Speed and stealing thunder	Disclosing bad news first, quickly, with what is known and what to do, reduces damage.	Waiting until the media asks or until every fact is certain.	The organization knows before the media does.
5	Spokesperson conduct	Say what is known, admit what isn't, give the next update time; never say "no comment" or speculate.	Guessing to fill silence.	A reporter asks about an unknown cause.
6	Bridging in media interviews	Answer the question briefly and truthfully, then bridge to the key message; don't repeat hostile wording.	Denying with the reporter's negative words, or ignoring the question.	A loaded or hostile question.
7	Internal audiences in a crisis	Employees, especially frontline staff, must be briefed with talking points before or with the public announcement.	Staff learning from the news.	Employees surprised by the crisis news.
8	Crisis plan essentials	A usable plan has a crisis team with roles, pre-approved holding statements, current contact lists, and drills.	Writing everything after the crisis starts.	Building or reviewing a crisis plan.

Course scope (public description): Crisis Communication prepares students to plan for and manage crisis responses. Students will analyze the stages of a crisis, create plans and messages for managing a crisis, and coach spokespeople to deliver the appropriate message using multiple channels. While engaging in a crisis communication simulation, students will explore how to establish and maintain message positioning, foster working relationships with news and media agencies, and build trust within stakeholder communities. Students will create internal and external crisis response communication plans to ensure coordinated, unified, and effective messaging.